

Primary auxiliary verbs

The verbs *be*, *have*, and *do* are known as the primary auxiliary verbs. Primary auxiliary verbs can be used as the main verb in a sentence, or they can be used with participles to form tenses. These verbs also have participles of their own. Auxiliary verbs are irregular verbs, and are irregular even in the present tense.

Verb form	be	have	do
Infinitive	be	have	do
First person (present)	am, are	have	do
Second person (present)	are	have	do
Third person (present)	is, are	has, have	does, do
Past participle	been	had	done
Present participle	being	having	doing

• Only the **primary auxiliaries**—*be*, *have*, and *do*—can **change** their form. **Modal auxiliaries** always take the **same form**.

• *Might* is the past tense of *may*, so *might* is always used when talking about something that might have happened previously.

• Sometimes modal auxiliaries are used to add **emphasis** to a decision or a command. Using *will* instead of *am going to* for the **first person** future tense makes a statement sound more determined: for example, “I **will** go to the party.”

Modal auxiliary verbs

Common auxiliary verbs that cannot be used on their own are known as modal auxiliary verbs. These include *can*, *will*, *should*, *may*, and *must*, and they are used with action verbs to express a command, an obligation,

or a possibility. Modal auxiliaries are unusual because they do not have an infinitive form or participles, nor—unlike primary auxiliaries and regular verbs—do they take the ending -s for the third person singular.

He **can** go.

The third person singular modal auxiliary does not take an -s; “he cans” doesn’t make sense.

Modal auxiliary	Use	Example
can	Used to express a person’s ability to do something.	I can run fast.
could	Used to show possibility; also the past form of <i>can</i> .	I could run faster.
may	Used to ask permission to do something, or to express a possibility.	May I come?
might	Used to express a small possibility; also the past form of <i>may</i> .	I might run away.
must	Used to indicate a strong obligation.	I must come.
ought	Used to express a sense of obligation.	I ought to stay.
shall	Used to form the future simple tense, and to show determination.	I shall run faster.
should	Used to express obligation.	I should come.
will	Used to form the future simple tense, and to show determination or issue a command.	You will come!
would	Used to express a polite question or a wish, or to indicate the consequence of a conditional sentence; also the past form of <i>will</i> .	Would you like to come? I would love to come. If I were to come, I would have fun.